British were seen as illegitimate rulers, because they failed to meet the established demands of the political culture in the country, and fulfil the expectation that ‘legitimate’ rulers must protect and promote Buddhism as an integral part of Burmese culture.[51]

The British preference for employing Indians in the colonial civil service and administrative structures further aggravated the situation. The result was that anti-British feeling was stronger in the Buddhist, mainly ethnically Burman communities,[52] while many minority ethnic groups were pro-British—particularly the Muslim Rohingyas and the Christian Karen. The link between religion, ethnicity and anti-British sentiment had a profound influence on the dynamics of the independence movement which would ultimately lead to the emergence of the Myanmar we know today. This had immediate consequences, as the independence movement sometimes took on a confessional and ethnic character. For example, the anti-colonial riots of 1938 were as much aimed at the Muslim community[53] as at British power. These riots followed on from the unsuccessful rural Saya San uprising in 1930 that had explicitly aimed to restore the pre-colonial Burmese polity.[54] The seeds for deep divisions in the country along religious lines had already been sown.

Things really came to a head during World War II. Burma became caught up in the war in 1942 when the Japanese invaded the area. Initially their arrival was welcomed by some Burmese nationalists who, as with the Indian Congress Party, saw the defeat of the British Empire as a step on the road to independence. However, the Rohingyas remained loyal to the British (as did many other non-Burmese ethnic groups), leading to significant ethnic strife[55] between the Rohingyas and Rakhine ethnic communities. It has been estimated that some 307 villages[56] were destroyed, 100,000 Rohingyas lost their lives and a further 80,000 fled the region[57] as a result. The Japanese also made matters worse when they carried out multiple massacres of the Rohingyas to punish them for their pro-British stance.[58] And one further consequence of the ethnic violence in 1942 was that it eliminated the old patchwork of ethnicities in Arakan and led to ethnic segregation between a largely Muslim north and a Buddhist south.

In turn, the British recruited soldiers from among the displaced Rohingyas, and, looking for allies, promised the Muslims of northern